



Kenya National Commission on Human Rights

Press Statement: *For Immediate Release*

28th May, 2026

Condolence Message following the Tragic Fire at Utumishi Girls Academy, Gilgil

The Kenya National Commission on Human Rights (KNCHR) extends its deepest sympathies and **heartfelt condolences** following the tragic fire at Utumishi Girls Academy, which claimed the lives of at least sixteen innocent students. Our hearts and prayers are with the bereaved families, friends, and the entire school community during this devastating time. We stand in solidarity with all those affected by this profound national loss, including survivors enduring profound psychological trauma.

This tragedy is a stark reminder of the critical importance of ensuring safe learning environments. The Commission reiterates that the **Right to Education is intrinsically linked to the Right to Life and Safety** and calls upon all relevant duty bearers to conduct a swift, thorough, impartial, and transparent investigation, and to ensure accountability for any acts of negligence or systemic failure.

The recurring cases of fires in boarding schools raise grave human rights concerns and demand urgent national reflection and action. Schools are not merely centres of learning, they are spaces where children are entrusted to the care and protection of the State and society. The loss of young lives through preventable tragedies points to gaps in compliance, preparedness, infrastructure, supervision, and emergency response systems. **It is unacceptable that children continue to face life-threatening risks in spaces meant to nurture their growth and future.**

This tragedy bears disturbing similarities to the 1998 Bombolulu and 2001 Kyanguli (67 deaths) school fires. Reports of locked emergency exits, students jumping from upper floors, and inadequate night supervision mirror failures criticised by previous commissions. Following Kyanguli, a taskforce made recommendations; in 2008, the Safety Standards Manual was developed; the 2016 Omolo Task Force and 2020 audit again found safety standards poorly understood or ignored. Following the September 2024 Hillside Enderasha fire (21 deaths), a nationwide assessment identified 348 schools failing minimum safety standards.

The tragedy today is not a lack of knowledge about what needs to be done, but the systemic failure to translate known recommendations into sustained action and accountability. **The KNCHR wishes to remind all schools and the Ministry of Education that these safety measures and recommendations are expected to be implemented consistently, in the interest of protecting learners and preventing avoidable tragedies.**

This tragedy calls for comprehensive rethinking of safety within Kenya's boarding school system. Beyond reactive responses, there is need for sustained investment in prevention, preparedness, accountability, and child-centred protection measures. This includes:

- **Regular and independent safety audits of all boarding schools;**
- **Enforcement of fire safety standards and building compliance regulations;**
- **Installation and maintenance of functional firefighting equipment and emergency exits;**
- **Adequate training of teachers, staff, and students on emergency preparedness and evacuation procedures;**
- **Strengthening psychosocial support systems for learners;**
- **Enhanced oversight by education authorities and school management boards and**
- **Meaningful participation of students in reporting safety concerns affecting their welfare.**

The Commission urges the Government, school administrators, parents, and all education stakeholders to place the safety, dignity, and welfare of learners at the centre of educational policy and governance. The safety of children can never be treated as secondary to academic performance, institutional reputation, or administrative convenience.

As a nation, we must collectively confront the painful reality that every preventable school fire represents not only a tragedy but also a failure in our duty of care to children. Kenya must move decisively from mourning recurring disasters to building a culture of prevention, accountability, and protection in all learning institutions.

The KNCHR stands ready to support all efforts aimed at strengthening child protection and school safety across the country.

The Kenya National Commission on Human Rights (KNCHR) is an Independent National Human Rights Institution (NHRI) established under Article 59 of the Constitution of Kenya, 2010 and the KNCHR Act, 2011. The Commission's mandate is the promotion and protection of human rights in Kenya.

Haki Kwa Wote, Kila Wakati!

Claris Ogangah,



Chairperson, Kenya National Commission on Human Rights (KNCHR).